

ARE WE ALONE IN THE UNIVERSE?

Earth is the one place in the universe where life exists for sure. Yet there are other planets and galaxies beyond our own, so who is to say there is no chance of life elsewhere? Many scientists believe that other life exists, although no definite proof has been presented. Life from anywhere other than our planet is called extraterrestrial (ET). In 1961, an American astrophysicist named Frank Drake came up with an equation, called the Drake equation, to estimate the number of ET civilizations in our galaxy that could contact us. It is estimated that there are about 10,000 potentially communicative ET civilizations. Toward the end of the 1990s, scientists began looking for ET life, from nearby Mars to remote planets orbiting distant stars.

ALIEN SPACECRAFT

Since World War II, there have been a huge number of reported sightings of unidentified flying objects (UFOs), especially over the southwest U.S. and Mexico. In 1947, American pilot Kevin Arnold described flying-saucer shapes in the sky, and afterward, the number of reported UFO sightings escalated dramatically. In the same year, a town called Roswell in New Mexico became a hotbed of UFO speculation after it was claimed that an alien spacecraft had crashed there. Rancher William Brazel heard an explosion on July 2 and went to investigate. He found strange metal debris covering almost 1 mile (1.6 km). The local newspaper

published Brazel's claim, but insisted that it was the remains of a crashed weather balloon. Eyewitnesses kept coming forward to tell a similar story, saying they had seen a UFO in the sky and metal wreckage on the ground.

MISTAKEN OBSERVATION

Scientific studies have found that most UFO sightings are genuine observations of objects in the sky, but further investigation reveals them to be aircraft, balloons, clouds, distant planets, or optical illusions. A few are even set up deliberately by photographers looking for fame. It is estimated that between five and 20 percent of sightings are truly unidentified, and it is these that UFO enthusiasts cite as evidence that we may not be alone in the universe.

SEARCH PARTY

An organized group called Search for Extraterrestrial Intelligence (SETI) has been set up to look for proof of life elsewhere. SETI scientists use radio telescopes positioned on Earth to pick up possible signals from ET life. No messages have been picked up to date. About 100 years ago, life was thought to exist on Mars because markings on the planet's surface were interpreted as canals built by a civilization. In more recent times, evidence has suggested that water once flowed on Mars and that the planet might have been suited to life. However, no proof of past organic life has been found, so the search for ET life continues.